

THE WRATH OF ARCHIE ELLIS



m kirk

OPENING PAGES

A note on the ground

The novel takes place in the Ypres Salient, in Belgium, between the thirty-first of July and the fourteenth of November 1917.

The offensive was the Third Battle of Ypres, which the British came to call Passchendaele. The ground is low farmland, drained for centuries, and three years of shelling destroyed the system that kept it dry. The water sits close to the surface there, and a hole dug in it fills from the bottom. Ground higher than the ground beside it was worth having and worth recording.

Places are given as the army gave them. The real places are on the maps. The sector's own names for its own ground are on none of them, and that is deliberate. B7, the Myrm, Regent Street, Oxford Circus, the Kasteel farm, Forty-Three: these were the battalion's names for its own few hundred yards, and the battalion is invented. A reader who went looking for them on the ground would find nothing, which is the correct result.

The battle is real and everyone in it is invented, including the generals. Who held those commands, and the one real life this book borrowed from, are at the back.

The novel is in British spelling. *Serjeant*, with a j, is a rifle regiment's own form and not a misprint. The notes at the back are in American spelling, because they are mine and not the battalion's.

The German is left as it stands, including one signals entry that runs to three sentences. So is one line of Latin.

There are notes, a glossary and a list of who is who at the back. The novel does not require any of it.

Proem

The wrath of Archie Ellis destroyed two hundred and forty-seven men. This is the account of that, set down as accurately as the surviving record permits, which is not accurately enough.

You will want a reason. So did the men standing beside him, and they had four months of him and I have had four years of the paper, and none of us has one. You will want to know what he felt. That is not in the paper and he did not say. What there is is the order in which it happened, and the documents, and what men told me afterwards when there was no longer anything to be gained by telling it. I have set that down.

It began on the thirty-first of July 1917, in the fourth year of the war, in the part of Belgium the maps call the Ypres Salient and the men call other things. It ended on a night in November that no one had planned. The generals had planned the rest. The offensives, the phases, the consolidations, the acceptable rates of loss per yard of ground. The wrath they did not plan. It is not in any file I have been given, and I have set it down where it fell.

Prologue

Roulers, 1921

The bar was loud in the way bars in that part of Belgium were loud in those years: men talking about what they had survived, and the noise itself a kind of proof. Some of the men at the counter had been coming in at the same hour since the Armistice, for reasons that had stopped being about the drink itself some time ago; a loud room that asked nothing of a man suited them better than the quiet of wherever they were otherwise supposed to be, and they had found, the way men do, that it was easier to keep coming back than to decide to stop.

He was at the bar with a Scotch. At a nearby table, four young men were celebrating – one of them, still in his good coat, had a son born that week, and the table had been drinking to it since early evening in the expanding, repetitive way of men who intend to keep drinking to it. Between toasts, one of them was telling a story. A name came up several times. The story improved with each telling – the details dropping away, the shape hardening into something cleaner and more useful than what had happened.

He had been coming back for four years and had enough of the language to follow a story he already knew.

One of them had noticed him. An Englishman, alone at the bar, a connection to the source material. He came over with the directness of a man who had had enough to drink and trusted it. He had a little English, off the ones who came in the summers to look for graves, and he used it.

“You have been there? You have known him?”

He said he had served in the same sector.

The young man’s English did not reach the answer. They went into German, which he had four years of from the men billeted in his house, and the Englishman had from paper rather than from people.

The young man called to his friends. The table turned. They had questions: what was he like, in the field, with his men, under fire? What had Mannon been like?

He looked at his whisky.

He said, in English: "He kept a very clean uniform."

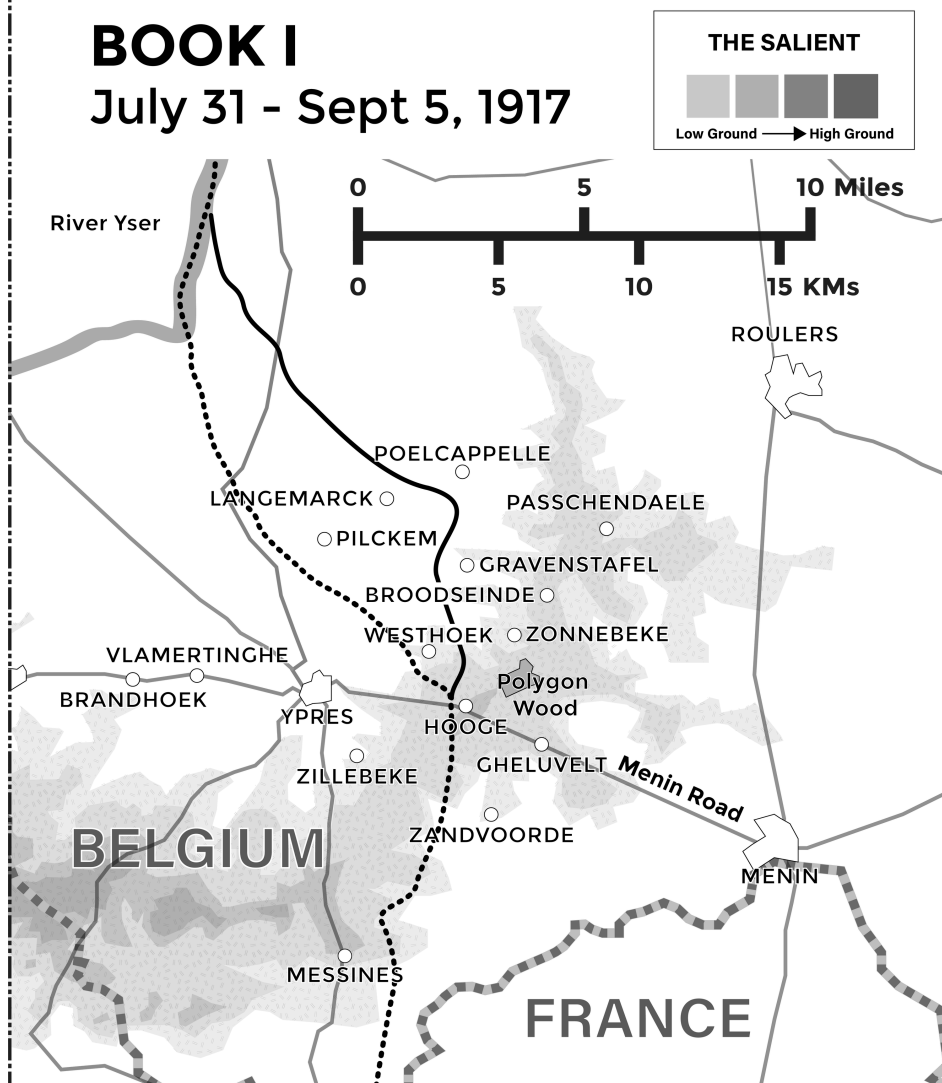
The sentence was short enough for the English he had. He laughed, and put it into Flemish for the table, and they nodded – the officer who maintained standards, the officer who looked like an officer under any conditions. The new father said he had already settled on the boy's name, if his wife agreed, once he found the courage to say so. The general's men had come into their village on a morning in the October of 1918, after four years of the other lot, and his mother had stood in the road and watched them come, and the boy would be Arthur. The table raised their glasses. No one asked what he had been afraid of.

He left money on the bar. He put on his coat. Outside, the Flemish dark was ordinary and cold, smelling of nothing in particular, and he walked until he found somewhere else to be.

In the bar behind him, the name continued for another hour before closing time – the way a tune outlives the man who first hummed it, going on being hummed to a different measure than his.

BOOK I

July 31 - Sept 5, 1917



The offensive opened on 31 July. In the north and centre the British went forward about 3,000 yards, taking Pilkem Ridge and reaching St Julien. On the Gheluvelt plateau to the south, where the German defence was strongest, they gained little. Rain began that afternoon, and August 1917 delivered 127mm, most of it on five days. Langemarck fell on 16 August, but repeated attacks on the plateau failed. By the end of August the British had suffered more than 68,000 casualties, killed, wounded and missing. The deepest advance, in the north, was close to three miles, and on the plateau the line had barely moved.

BOOK I

Wrath

The Invocation

31 July 1917

The Ypres Salient was a bowl. This was not a metaphor the men used – it was the physical fact of the ground. The British held the inside. The Germans held the eastern rim – a long arc of ridge that curved from the north-east, where the ground rose towards Passchendaele, east through the Gheluvelt Plateau, and south to where the high ground above Zandvoorde, held since the war's first autumn, closed the arc. The west was open, back towards Poperinghe and the coast. That was the only reason the Salient could be held at all. The geometry had been producing the same result for three years. The men in the bowl could not move east without being seen, and the men on the rim could fire down into it across nearly every angle of approach.

This was why they could not leave. Behind them, forty miles west, lay the Channel ports – Calais, Boulogne, Dunkirk – and behind those the sea, which ran round the whole of it and was the edge of the thing. There was no position to fall back to that was not also a position from which England could be cut off. They held the Salient because they could not afford to give it up. That was one way of understanding it. The other way was to look east, where past the rim the Belgian plain opened flat and undefended, and there was nothing between the Allied armies and Germany that the maps could show. The ridges had been attacked in 1915 and in 1916. They were still German.

They moved east on the road. It went out of the town towards the front, running low between the shell-pocked fields. It had been planked in sections, the wood grey and slick, and where the planking ended it was rubble and mud and the dried ruts of previous convoys. Men did not walk in the road if they could help it. They walked on the verges, beside it, making

the sound a large body of men makes when it is trying not to be heard: not silence but a low complicated sound, equipment carried and managed, boots finding purchase, breathing adjusted to pace. None of them were singing.

What they were walking out of had been a town. The Cloth Hall had no roof and had not had one since 1915. It had been built to weigh and sell cloth and it had done that for six hundred years. The water tower had no top. The church of Saint Martin's stood to three-quarters of its height on its eastern side and to less than half on its western, where the shell damage had been more thorough. These were the fixed points of the landscape, known to every man who had served in the Salient and named in the shorthand that fixed points acquire when they have been visible long enough: the Hall, the tower, the stump. The men on the Menin Road in the last hour of darkness before the barrage passed all three without looking at them, which was not indifference but the same relationship they had with their own breathing.

The column had a smell that reached the verge before the sound did and stayed after it had gone: wet wool, rifle oil, and four thousand men who had not been able to wash since the twenty-eighth.

The rim of the bowl was invisible in the darkness. To the east, the German line sat on Passchendaele Ridge and Broodseinde and Polygon Wood and the other positions, which the men knew by what came from them. The guns had been firing on those positions since the sixteenth of July. Nothing was firing now. That was the sound the men were listening past. Zero hour was 0350. Every man on the road knew the time, and the direction it would come from, and roughly what it would do to the men at the front of the column.

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Before the guns started, the road filled with men.

An American stood above the road and watched them pass.

He had found a section of broken parapet – an old breastwork, partially collapsed – that gave him three feet of elevation above the road's surface, enough to look down the line of movement rather than into it. He had been there since before the column started coming through, having positioned himself in the dark by feel and by the memory of where the parapet was from two days before, when he had walked this ground in daylight to find the angle he wanted. He had his camera. He had two spare plates and a

tripod he was not using because the shutter speed he needed in this light made the tripod useful and the tripod made him slower to reposition. He had already decided that repositioning was more important than absolute steadiness, because what he was looking for was the line of their faces coming towards him and the line of their faces was not a stable thing.

He had not asked anyone for help with what he was looking for. There was no one to ask.

He was looking for it and could not find it. The men were there, moving through his field of view with the efficiency of men who had done this before. What he was trying to find in their faces was not available to the camera. He had known photographers who said the camera always found what was there if you knew where to look. There was a category of things that were entirely present and entirely visible and entirely beyond the camera's reach – as if the thing he needed was a name spoken over them, not a shutter.

He lowered the camera. He watched them go.

One man near the front of the column was carrying something in addition to his standard kit – a roll of canvas or oilskin, strapped horizontally across his pack – that made his silhouette distinctive, wider across the shoulders than the men around him. He moved at the column's pace. He did not look up at the parapet. He passed and went into the dark ahead.

Another man, further back, was walking with the deliberate placing of someone managing a bad foot – not limping, not falling behind, but putting each step down with a fraction more attention than the men around him. His cap was pushed back on his head. He was looking at the road in front of him, calculating the surface, thinking about nothing else.

Then more men, and more, and the column thickened and thinned and thickened again as units bunched and spread, and the American on the parapet watched all of it and could not make it into the thing he was trying to make it into, which was a record.

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When the column was past, he stayed where he was. The dark had not changed, but its quality had. Below the parapet line, along the forward trench, a figure was moving.

The American had caught it in peripheral vision first – the figure moving the way a man moves when the ground is his responsibility. He raised the camera. Not the posture of command but the attention of it. The men in the trench near him oriented towards him without appearing to. The lens was on him before he had decided to raise it. He shot. He shot again.

When the light was sufficient, he saw that the uniform was wrong. No red tabs on the collar. The tunic was caked with the mud of the forward trench, the dark clay of the Salient floor, not the mud of a road or a billet. There was a ribbon bar on the chest, and above it the Victoria Cross, worn on a field tunic in a forward trench, which he had not seen done. He noted both, and would check the rest later. This was not Mannon.

The figure had stopped. He was looking up at the parapet.

The American lowered the camera.

“Where do I find Colonel Mannon’s position?”

He asked it that way because a preamble produced worse results.

The figure looked at him for a moment. He did not ask what the American wanted with the colonel, or who he was, or what the camera was for.

He said: “Vlamertinghe. Five miles west.”

Then he turned back to the wire. The American had come up the line to find something and was being sent five miles in the other direction to look for it. He put the camera back under his coat and went.

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Somewhere east of the road, in the gun pits and battery positions that had been prepared over the previous weeks, the guns were waiting for the order that had already been issued, that was already moving towards them through wire and runner and the accumulated machinery of a command structure, descending by stages towards the men on the road – the chain extending from this road back to Mannon’s headquarters at Vlamertinghe, and from Vlamertinghe back to Montreuil, and from Montreuil back to London, and from London back, if you followed it far enough, to a morning in August 1914 and a treaty signed in 1839 guaranteeing the neutrality of the country the men were currently walking through, that nobody, including the men who had been in the room when the decisions were made, was now prepared to explain with any precision. The chain was intact. The order

was in transit. The guns would fire at 0350, which was when they were supposed to fire.

It was now 0331.

* * *

Captain Ellis was in the dugout called B7. He had B Company, which the battalion called the Myrm.

B7 was not far from the road. It was a little further forward than the main officer accommodation – close enough to hear what the men on the Myrm sector heard, and far enough from Mannon's nightly consultations to make attendance technically difficult. The dugout had been built by men who understood timber and corrugated iron and the angle at which a roof would shed a near-miss without coming down. It had two bunks. It had a table and a lamp and a pair of hooks for kit and a shelf above the upper bunk where a tin box of Cornish make with a scallop shell imprint pressed into the lid sat in the same position it had occupied since Ellis arrived at the Salient. It was not army issue.

Ellis was sitting at the table. He was not reading, though there was a paper in front of him. He was listening to the road.

Hargreaves came in from outside, which he had been doing at intervals for an hour. He moved quietly and did not speak unless he had determined that speech would not make things worse, which was the correct approach for the current morning. He went to the lamp and adjusted it by an amount that made no difference to the light. He turned it up and turned it back down.

Then he put the kettle on the small stove in the corner. He did not ask Ellis if he wanted tea. He had been Ellis's batman for nine months and understood that the question was unnecessary.

Ellis said: "How many?"

Hargreaves said: "All of them."

Ellis nodded. He folded the paper, which was a dispatch from Mannon's headquarters containing the summary of events for the thirty-first of July in the language that summaries of events used – euphemism, confident and forward-looking, specific about objectives and vague about cost. Ellis had read it twice. The objectives were the first German line, the Gheluvelt

Plateau, the Roulers road beyond. Between the men he had just heard going past on the road and that ground lay, in order: the wire, which had been cut or had not been cut depending on which report you accepted, and the first German line, which was not a line in the sense the maps implied but a system of mutually supporting positions designed by men who had had time to think about it. Then, past that, the mud – the load-bearing, fundamental mud of the Salient floor that had been receiving the impact of three years of shells and three years of rain and had become not a landscape feature but a medium, something you moved through rather than across, at a rate the dispatch had not included in its calculations.

He put the dispatch in his breast pocket. The order it described did not require him specifically. It required a captain at B7. He was the captain at B7. He stood up. He took his helmet from the hook and his revolver from the other hook and did up what needed doing up. He had eaten at six the previous evening. He did not eat again that day.

The kettle had not boiled.

He went out.

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The barrage started at 0350, which was when it was supposed to start.

It did not begin so much as arrive, the way weather arrives, all at once and without a source you could point to. The ground took it and passed it up through the boots of the men on the road. There was no single sound to it. There was the sound, and then there was the condition, and the condition did not stop.

The American raised his camera and tried to photograph the sky.

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The barrage had been going for ninety minutes when the gap appeared.

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A shell – not a wire-cutting round, not part of the planned sequence – produced an eight-foot breach in the German wire forty yards left of where the cutting parties had worked. The machine-gun position covering the gap on an enfilade line had been suppressed. The suppression would end in approximately ninety seconds. The barrage was moving forward on schedule.

Ellis was not supposed to be forward. His coordinating position was behind the leading platoons. He was at the forward trench line.

The commanding officer had been forward since the leading company stopped, which was not his position either. Protheroe was killed at ten past five, at the lip of the emplacement, by the gun that was about to be suppressed. The battalion had a commanding officer at five o'clock and did not have one at eleven minutes past.

Ellis saw the gap.

He took Company Serjeant Major Stanley Jacks and Lieutenant Baldwin Doyle and went through at a run.

The emplacement was concrete, three men, the machine gun not yet back in action after the suppression. Ellis was through the entrance before it was. Thirty seconds. The three men were no longer an operational problem. The machine gun was theirs.

They held it for four hours. The floor stood in water to the ankle and there was nowhere for it to go. The assault consolidated around them. The battalion's right flank held.

Mannon's dispatch, filed that evening, recorded that the Myrm sector's performance had been exemplary throughout. Ellis's name did not appear.

The dispatch reached B7 at 1940. Ellis read it at the table. He folded it along its original crease and put it in his breast pocket. The tin box was on the shelf above the upper bunk. He sat for a time without moving.

* * *

The American was above the road when the gap opened. He had the lens on the wire. He saw three men go through – one ahead of the others, moving faster than the other two. He shot the gap. He shot the run. He shot the entry.

He had the image. He did not have the name.